the passive and its uses

FORM

Use ***be*** + ***past participle*** to form the passive.

present simple active	We **find** oil and gas beneath the ground or sea.
present simple passive	*Oil and gas* ***are found*** *beneath the ground or sea.*
present continuous active	The police are **questioning** two men.
present continuous passive	*Two men* ***are being questioned*** *by the police.*
past simple active	Teachers **trained** Aztec boys to fight.
past simple passive	*Aztec boys* ***were trained*** *to fight.*
present perfect active	Tourism **has harmed** some countries.
present perfect passive	*Some countries* ***have been harmed*** *by tourism.*
will active	We **will choose** a new class representative on Monday.
will passive	*A new class representative* **will be chosen** *on Monday.*

USE

Use the passive

- to move important information (the object of the active sentence) to the beginning.
  Two men ***are being questioned*** *by the police.*
- when we want to be impersonal and not mention the name of the person who performs the action. We often use the passive in scientific or technical processes.
  Oil and gas ***are found*** *beneath the ground or sea.*
- when it is obvious who performed the action, eg teachers, or we do not want to use a general subject eg *people, they*.
  Aztec boys ***were trained*** *to fight.*
  Two missing children ***have been found*** *safe and well.*
- more often in formal speech and writing than in everyday speech.

transitive and intransitive

Verbs which have an object are called transitive verbs; verbs without an object are intransitive. Only transitive verbs can be made passive.

	subject	verb	object	
transitive	*I*	*lost*	*my wallet*	*on the way to school.*
intransitive	*I*	*swim*	–	*every day.*

Use *by*

- when it is important to know the 'agent' or person who performed the action
  Some countries have been harmed ***by tourism.***
- only when it is really necessary.
  The two men were arrested. (by the police – this is obvious)

Use *with*

- for objects which perform actions.
  The game was played ***with a ball of solid rubber.***

1 Complete the sentence with the past simple passive form of the verb in brackets.

a In ancient times, fires (light) were lit to use smoke as a signal over long distances.
b Morse code (invent) _____ by an American called Samuel Morse.
c The world's first television images (show) _____ to scientists in Scotland in 1926.
d Radios (use) _____ to broadcast coded messages during the Second World War.
e The World Wide Web (design) _____ originally to make it easier for nuclear physics researchers to communicate.
f Buying books and CDs over the Internet (make) _____ popular by the company Amazon.
g The first mobile phones with cameras (sell) _____ in Japan.
h Vinyl albums and tapes (replace) _____ by CDs, which are now being replaced by mp3.
i The first English dictionary (wrote) _____ by Robert Cawdrey in 1604.
j The first mass-produced cars (introduce) _____ by the Ford company in the USA.

2 Read the text and underline all the subject, verb and object structures. Then rewrite the text using present simple passive verbs. Leave out any unnecessary words.

How a toy car is made

In the factory, they use a computer to plan the exact shape of the car. They then feed this computer program into a machine, and produce a plastic prototype. Then they produce the actual toy cars in a factory abroad. As far as construction is concerned, they make the bodies of the cars from plastic. They add small electric motors to the cars, and then they paint them. They also attach licence plates. Quality control inspects the cars and then they wrap them and pack them into cardboard boxes. They ship the cars to Britain.

a As a first step, a computer is used to plan the exact shape of the car.
b Then _____ and _____
c The actual _____
d The bodies _____
e Small _____
Licence _____
f At the next stage, _____
g Finally, _____ Britain.

social studies

3 Complete the text with either the *will* passive or present perfect passive forms of the verbs in brackets.

In recent years many plans a (make) *have been made* for large floating cities with living accommodation for as many as 50,000 people. One such project which b (advertise) _____ is the Freedom Ship. According to the plans for this project, this huge ship c (construct) _____ from smaller units, which d (take) _____ out to sea for final assembly. The ship e (power) _____ by 100 diesel engines, and the residents on board f (carry) _____ around the world continuously.



The large number of people on the ship g (provide) _____ with all kinds of entertainment and sports facilities, and modern recycling methods h (use) _____ to save energy on board. At the time of writing, this project i (not build) _____, and j (criticize) _____ by some people who say it is too expensive. We shall have to wait and see whether this ambitious plan ever becomes reality.

GLOSSARY

4 Rewrite the sentence using a present perfect passive with *by*. Leave out any unnecessary words.

a Cheaper air travel has made possible the global expansion in tourism.
The global expansion in tourism has been made possible by cheaper air travel.

b Countries all over the world have experienced a growth in tourism.
_____

c Millions of tourists have visited the popular Mediterranean resorts since the 1970s.
_____

d Recently tourists have chosen more distant locations in Africa, Asia and South America.
_____

e Mass tourism has badly affected some countries.
_____

f International companies have built large hotels on unspoilt coastline.
_____

g These developments have disturbed local wildlife.
_____

h Tourists have damaged coral reefs and other habitats.
_____

i Such developments have also displaced local people.
_____

j Some governments have developed the idea of ecotourism to counteract some of these problems.
_____

5 Read the information about urban development. Then complete the text with the present perfect passive or past perfect passive form of the verbs in brackets.



In many countries in recent years, areas of urban land which were once used for industrial purposes a (redevelop) *have been redeveloped* for other purposes. In London, for example, the Docklands b (transform) _____ since the 1980s. The docks c (built) _____ in the 19th century when London was a busy port, but by the 1980s, most business d (lose) _____, and many docks e (close) _____. This left large areas of derelict land, and many people without jobs. Since the 1980s, £10 billion (€14.7 billion) f (spend) _____ on the project. 600 hectares of derelict land g (improve) _____, 90 km of new roads h (build) _____, 80,000 new jobs i (create) _____ and 24,000 new homes j (construct) _____. In addition to this, 100,000 new trees k (plant) _____ and 130 hectares of parks l (create) _____. Cultural venues such as the Docklands Arena m (open) _____. Some local people do not agree with all the things that n (do) _____, as houses here are expensive, and most jobs are in media, IT or business. On the other hand, a declining area of the city o (give) _____ a new lease of life.

GLOSSARY

6A Rewrite each sentence so that it does not contain the words *someone* or *people*.

a Someone built ships with sails more than 5,000 years ago.
Ships with sails were built more than 5,000 years ago.

b Someone constructed a hot-air balloon in 1783.

c People developed the steam ship in the 19th century.

d Someone opened the first successful passenger railway in 1830.

e People started the first passenger airlines after the First World War.

6B Rewrite each sentence so that it includes the agent *by*.

f The Chinese probably printed the first books more than a thousand years ago.

g The Remington company sold the first modern typewriters in the 1870s.

h Edison recorded the first words on a gramophone record in 1877.

i The Lumière brothers created the first modern cinema in France in 1895.

j Valdemar Poulsen invented the tape recorder in 1899.